outspoken critic of the Nixon–Kissinger foreign policy, make remarks significant for its reconciliatory underpinning. She was quoted as saying, ‘Any two countries, any two individuals, have their ups and [downs][sic] … They’re on the way up now.’

Ratan’ reputation and stature also led to an unprecedented demand for his association with government, public and private bodies. No other Indian leader has been associated with so many foreign organizations and been conferred as many foreign awards as him.

The clamour for his participation has been from across India and abroad. ‘He is a national asset,’ says Greenberg. Ratan was the chairperson of the Quality Council of India (1997–1999), a member of the PM’s Council on Climate Change (2007–2014), a member of the Sub-Committee on Promoting PPP specially in R&D and clean energy, and of the PM’s Council on Trade and Industry, and is currently a trustee of PM Cares, amongst several others.

But of all the bodies Ratan has been associated with, one that he was personally excited about was his appointment on the Board of Governors of the East-West Center of Hawaii in 1993. He served several terms on it until 2004. He was reappointed in 2013 and he continues to be on it, though of late on account of his health, he is not very active.

‘I love Hawaii,’ he comments, and added, ‘any connection of a lasting nature was an excuse for me to be associated with Hawaii.’ ‘I looked forward to the board meetings’, as they were an excuse to be in Hawaii, he confesses unabashedly. His involvement with the centre was at its acme during the time when George Ariyoshi, the first-ever governor of Hawaii of Japanese ancestry, was its head.

Ariyoshi had served as a member and chairman of the Board of Governors of the centre (1995–2003). They became friends and worked closely together, says Ratan. Their association led to new links being forged with India, Thailand, Malaysia and New Zealand, for instance.

In 2001, in ‘a rare distinction for an Indian in [a] Chinese government-backed influential body’, Ratan was appointed as a member of the Boao Forum for Asia (BFA). The other members included former Prime Ministers Yasuo Fukuda (Japan), Abdullah Ahmad Badawi (Malaysia), Goh Chok Tong (Singapore), Jean-Pierre Raffarin (France) and former US Secretary of the Treasury Henry M. Paulson. In 2005, he was inducted as a member in the International Advisory Panel (IAP) of the Monetary Authority of